

OCEAN TRADE AND TOURISM

Oceans have always been important trading routes. Ships still provide one of the most efficient ways of transporting heavy materials such as oil over long distances, while container ships carry all kinds of goods, from frozen food to cars and computers. The sea is also an important element of the tourist trade, because most of the places that tourists visit are beach resorts. Many people even enjoy traveling by sea, either on big cruise ships or on their own small yachts, pitting their sailing skills against the power of the ocean.



▲ BULK CARRIERS AND CONTAINERS

Ships are the only economic means of carrying heavy materials like oil and sand across the oceans, and container ships like this one can carry a colossal amount of cargo. This is because a ship and its load are supported by the water, and the amount of fuel needed to propel it does not increase in proportion with the weight of its payload. By contrast, an aircraft uses a huge quantity of fuel simply staying airborne, and this increases with every extra pound of freight that it carries.



▲ CANAL LINKS

Oceanic trading became safer and quicker when the Suez Canal in Egypt and the Panama Canal in Central America were built in the 19th and early 20th centuries, respectively. By cutting through the narrow necks of land linking the great continents, the canals enabled ships to trade between the Indian, Atlantic, and Pacific Oceans without making long, dangerous voyages around the stormy southern capes of Africa and South America.

trade and
tourism



◀ BUSY PORTS

Most coastal cities were built using the wealth created by the ocean trade. Some still have busy ports, but today many ships dock at terminals that are situated far from city centers. These facilities are often especially designed for handling specific cargo, like these containers.